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The Indian patent story: Why private universities file more patents than IITs combined

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India has crossed 1 lakh patent filings in 2024–25, with educational institutes driving a sharp 62% jump in just one year. Private universities now dominate filings, overtaking the IITs. But do these numbers reflect genuine innovation, or just a push to climb rankings? This deep dive unpacks patent filings versus grants, tracks incentives and reimbursements, and examines real-world commercial impact to understand what is truly fuelling India's university patent boom.

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India crossed 1.1 lakh patent filings in 2024–25, with educational institutes driving a 61.7% surge. Private universities dominate filing numbers, overtaking the IITs, but patent grant rates and commercialisation remain uneven. (AI-generated image)

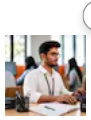
By: Roshni Chakrabarty
New Delhi, Feb 24, 2026 10:53 IST

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When a Chinese robodog at the India AI summit blew up into the Galgotias fiasco, a flurry of social-media posts followed with the viral claim: private universities in India are filing more patents than the IITs combined.


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The screenshots accompanying these viral posts, that show Galgotias at number 3 with 1080 patents filed and the IITs at number 5 with 803, are however from the 2022–23 Intellectual Property annual report from the Government of India's Patent Office, not the latest 2024–25 figures.

Country	Total Patent Grants 2023	% of Granted Patent	Total Patent Applications	Non-Resident Patent Grants	Non-Resident Patent Grants %	Resident Patent Grants	Resident Patent Grants %
China	798,347	49	1,619,268	102,756	13	695,591	87
United States	323,410	54	594,340	181,472	56	141,938	44
Japan	201,420	70	289,530	46,303	23	155,117	77
South Korea	135,180	57	237,633	35,978	27	99,202	73
India	30,490	40	77,068	22,703	74	7,787	26
Germany	23,592	41	57,213	9,667	41	13,925	59

(f) Top 10 Indian Applicants for Patents from Academic Institutes and Universities:

Sl. No.	Name of Institutes/Universities	Applications filed
1	LOVELY PROFESSIONAL UNIVERSITY	1387
2	JAIN (DEEMED-TO-BE UNIVERSITY)	1093
3	GALGOTIAS UNIVERSITY	1089
4	TEERTHANKER MAHAVEER UNIVERSITY	1007
5	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY(Collectively)	803
6	CHANDIGARH UNIVERSITY	752
7	CHANDIGARH GROUP OF COLLEGES	733
8	SANSKRITI UNIVERSITY	600
9	HINDUSTHAN COLLEGE OF ENGINEERING AND TECHNOLOGY	302
10	SHOBHIT INSTITUTE OF ENGINEERING AND TECHNOLOGY (DEEMED TO-BE UNIVERSITY)	301

Viral screenshot of 'Top 10 Applicants for Patents from Academic Institutes and Universities' from Intellectual Property of India 2022-23 report

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But even though Galgotias does not feature in the newest top-10 Indian patent filers list from educational institutes, private and deemed-private universities still dominate the rankings. Thus, the main concern remains very much alive.

To understand what is really happening, we need to unpack three things: the scale of India's patent boom, how the patent system actually works, and what incentives universities are responding to.

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INDIA CROSSES 1 LAKH PATENT FILINGS

The Intellectual Property of India Patents Annual Report 2024–25 notes that India crossed the 1 lakh patent filings mark for the first time. It is a milestone year with filings increasing from 92,168 in 2023-24 to 1,10,375 in 2024-25, an increase of 19.75%.

A patent in India can be filed by an Indian resident or by a foreign (non-resident) applicant. Foreign companies and inventors file in India when they want to sell, manufacture, license, or protect their technology in the Indian market, because patent rights are territorial and only valid in the country where they are granted.

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In 2024-25, out of the 1.1 lakh patents filed in India, 68,201 filings came from Indian applicants, and 42,174 from foreign applicants. So roughly, domestic or Indian applicants now make up nearly 62% of total filings, which is a big uptick from last year's 56%.

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1.3 Category-Wise Distribution of Applications:

Following are details of applications filed by applicants of various categories such as Natural Person (NP), Startups (SU), Small Entity (SE), Educational Institutions (EI) and Other than Natural Persons (ONP) during the last five years. It may be noted that applications filed by all these categories mostly shows an upward trend.

Table. Trends in Category-Wise Patent of Applications

Year	Natural Person (NP)		Startups (SU)		Small Entity (SE)		Educational Natural Persons		Other than Institutes(EI)		Total		Grand Total
	Indian	Foreign	Indian	Foreign	Indian	Foreign	Indian	Foreign	Indian	Foreign			
2020-21	10844	1053	1598	13	744	53	0	0	11150	33048	24326	34167	58503
2021-22	12451	1324	1482	19	985	384	7405	96	7185	35109	29508	36932	66440
2022-23	14599	1261	2016	25	1329	429	19155	275	6202	37520	43301	39510	82811
2023-24	14431	1185	2546	25	3421	128	23306	237	7870	39019	51574	40594	92168
2024-25	**17170**	**1159**	**2680**	**24**	**2575**	**172**	**37681**	**213**	**8095**	**40606**	**68201**	**42174**	**110375**

Source: Intellectual property of India Annual Report 2024-25

But the biggest boom is in the 'Educational Institutes' category, where Indian institute filings jumped from 23,306 in 2023–24 to 37,681 in 2024–25. That is an increase of 14,375 applications in a single year, or a 61.7% growth.

Educational institutes in India are not just participating in the domestic patent boom. They are driving it. So what's the reason?

PRIVATE UNIVERSITIES DOMINATE THE TOP 10 LIST

The Intellectual Property Report 2024-25's table titled 'Top 10 Indian Applicants for Patents from Academic Institutes and Universities' shows:


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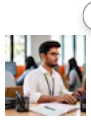
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Table. Top 10 Indian Applicants for Patents from Academic Institutes and Universities:

Sl. No.	Name of Institutes/Universities	Applications filed
1	LOVELY PROFESSIONAL UNIVERSITY	2241
2	SAVEETHA INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL AND TECHNICAL) SCIENCES (SIMATS	2038
3	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY (Collectively)	1740
4	JAIN (DEEMED-TO-BE UNIVERSITY)	1504
5	SIKSHA 'O' ANUSANDHAN (DEEMED-TO-BE UNIVERSITY)	995
6	SANSKRITI UNIVERSITY	703
7	SATHYABAMA INSTITUTE OF SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY	645
8	VELLORE INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY (VIT)	629
9	PRESIDENCY UNIVERSITY, BANGALORE	625
10	GRAPHIC ERA (DEEMED-TO-BE UNIVERSITY)	592

In this category, Lovely Professional University occupied the first position. Saveetha Institute of Medical And Technical Sciences (Simats) And Indian Institute Of Technology (Collectively) holds the second and third place, respectively, while Jain (Deemed-To-Be University) And Siksha 'O' Anusandhan (Deemed-To-Be University) occupied the fourth and fifth place, respectively.

Source: Intellectual property of India Annual Report 2024-25

Nine out of ten on this list are private or deemed-private institutions. Even collectively, IITs take up the third spot, not the first.

This is where the viral posts get their punchline from.

However, filing a patent is not the same as getting one granted.

Here's how patents work and the different between a filed and granted patent.

HOW THE PATENTING PROCESS WORKS

A granted patent gives the inventor exclusive legal rights to stop others from making, using, or selling the invention without permission.

For a layperson, here is how the patenting process works:

1. You file a patent application describing your invention.
2. The patent gets published. Almost all filed patents are published.
3. You must request examination for your published patent.
4. At the examination, the patent office raises objections.
5. You defend your claims.
6. Your patent is granted only if it survives scrutiny.
7. Your patent can then proceed to commercialisation.

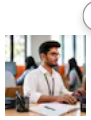
And only a few commercialised patents bring in real-word changes.

This whole process can fall apart at any level. Few move past the examination level.

Thus, it is far easier to file a patent, than to actually get one granted.


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IT FILED VS PATENT GRAN

The Intellectual Property Report **2024-25** notes:

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Patents filed: 1,10,375

Patents examined: 15,526

Patents granted: 33,504

Now, check the contrast with the **2023-24** report:

Patents filed: 92,168

Patents examined: 18,438

Patents granted: 1,03,057

In 2024-25, the number of patents granted is far fewer than the patents filed. In 2023-24, the number of patents granted was 67.49% higher. So while patent filings surged this year, patent grants fell sharply.

This creates a key distinction: while the number of patents filed is rising aggressively, the number of patents granted is not rising at the same pace.


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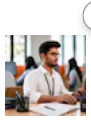
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Figure. Trends in Patent Applications

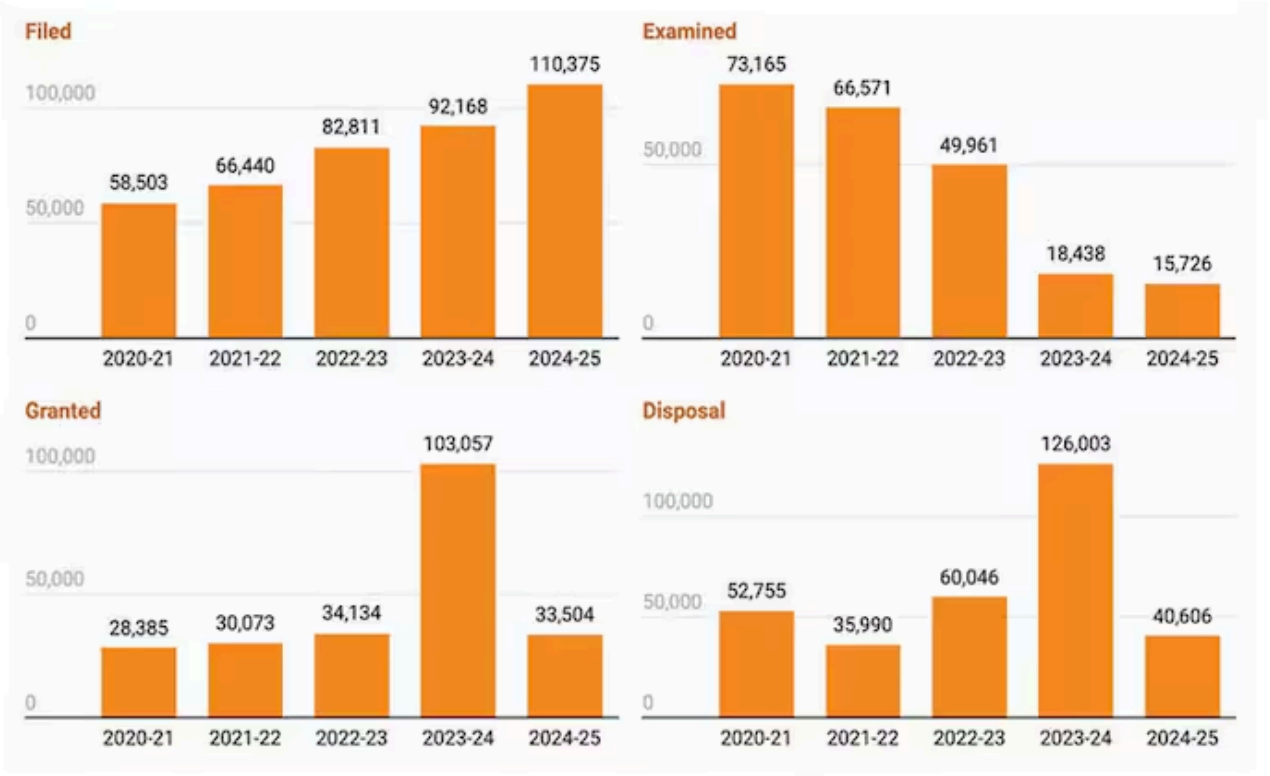


Table. Trends in Patent Applications

Year	2020-21	2021-22	2022-23	2023-24	2024-25
Filed	58503	66440	82811	92168	**110375**
Examined	73165	66571	49961	18438	**15726**
Granted	28385	30073	34134	103057	**33504**
Disposal	52755	35990*	60046	126003	**40606**

Source: Intellectual property of India Annual Report 2024-25

A closer reading of the data also shows that patents granted in certain years outnumber patents examined in the same period. How is that possible?

According to an Indian Patent Office (IPO) press release, the processing time for a patent is 12-30 months. So, the number of patents granted in a particular year does not have to come from applications filed in that same year.

But since patent examination is mandatory before grant, this apparent discrepancy raises important questions about how backlog clearances, patent examination timelines, and reporting categories are structured.

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ar-wise comparisons fully cap e depth of scrutiny applied in ing and granting patents?

ARE PRIVATE UNIVERSITIES MAKING MONEY FROM PATENT-FILING REIMBURSEMENTS?

IPO data shows a sharp surge in patent filings by Indian educational institutes, but grants have not risen at the same pace. This raises an obvious question: what is driving the filing boom?

Some viral posts allege that private universities are filing patents mainly to claim reimbursements under state startup or innovation schemes.

November 8, 2026 | 21:50 IST INDIA TODAY AAJ TAK INDIA TODAY HINDI NEWSTAK GNTTV LALLANTOP BUSINESS TODAY BANGLA MALAYALAM NORTHEAST BT BAZAAR

Under central policy, startups and educational institutions receive up to an 80% fee reduction on patent filing. State rules vary -- Karnataka reimburses 75% at filing and 25% after grant, while Uttar Pradesh reportedly pays only after grant. Reimbursements typically go up to Rs 2 lakh for Indian patents and Rs 5 lakh or 10 lakh for foreign filings.

Priya Mukherjee (name changed), a BTech alumnus from Amity University, and currently pursuing her MTech at an IIT, explains the cost reality of filing patents.

"The official government fees to are actually highly subsidised for educational institutions and students -- just Rs 1,600 for filing and Rs 4,000 for the examination request. However, the real financial hurdle is the professional drafting. Patent attorneys charge anywhere from Rs 40,000 to Rs 80,000+ to draft the claims properly," she says.

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So while government fees are low, professional drafting is expensive.



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(Photo: AI-generated image)

Komal Bandopadhyay (name changed), who completed her Btech and MTech from two private universities in India, and is now pursuing a PhD abroad, says: "Patent filing can cost Rs 20,000 to 2 lakhs depending on whether an external officer is required, an agent, drafting complexity, etc."

"After final stage, to maintain it for 20 years, Rs 2-5 lakhs are needed (around Rs 800 a year for the initial years). I believe reimbursement is a legal procedure here but most universities do not give enough that's spent," she adds.

While patent filing costs are manageable for large institutions, they are not insignificant, and reimbursement caps do not automatically translate into easy profit. With scrutiny attached to reimbursement claims, patent filing is unlikely to function as a straightforward money-making strategy.

Annual data from the Indian Patent Office also does not support the idea that reimbursement gaming is driving the patent filing boom among educational institutes.

As the following tables show, while overall patent-related expenditure rose between 2023–24 and 2024–25, reimbursement claims did not see a matching increase, suggesting refunds are not being aggressively tapped in proportion to spending.

Table. Details of revenue received and expenditure incurred with regard to Intellectual Property (IP)

Revenue details (in Lakhs)

Year	2020-21	2021-22	2022-23	2023-24	2024-25
Patents	62384	66749.31	72910.76	91397	89775.14
Designs	655	769.12	852.8	970.63	1206.05
Trade Marks	39671	41776.58	44465.09	42546.47	53582.19
Copyrights	248.81	323.85	241.07	345	364.76
GIR	5	8.35	13.68	11.9	18.57
SICLDR	0.25	0.1	0.4	0.1	0.3
PIS/RGNIIPM	12.35	20.48	20.66	12	0.27
Total	102976.41	109647.79	118504.46	135283.1	144947.28*

*Figures may vary subject to reconciliation

Table. Details of Refund of Request for Examination Fee under Rule 7(4A) of the Patents Rules

Financial Year	2020-21	2021-22	2022-23	2023-24	2024-25
Refund amount (Rs. In Lakhs)	145.61	182.93	23.542	63.48	32.53

Table. A comparison of expenditure from the budget allocated to the O/o CGPDTM

Financial Year	2020-21	2021-22	2022-23	2023-24	2024-25
CGPDTM	20157.68	20407.35	25205.09	27676.49	29567.9

Source: Intellectual property of India Annual Report 2024-25

So there must be some other motive behind the boom in patent filing.

Achal Agarwal, Founder of India Research Watch, named by Nature as one of the world's top science makers in 202

"The bigger motive is not the rein ents but the incentives

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"Most patents in the world create loss as innovation is risky and rarely succeeds. Some patents however turn out to be very useful and help recover the costs of other patents. For Indian institutions, the reason for filing patents is not just economic, but largely the rankings and the ratings system," he says.

That line explains a lot.

ARE RANKINGS THE REAL DRIVER BEHIND PATENT FILING BOOM?

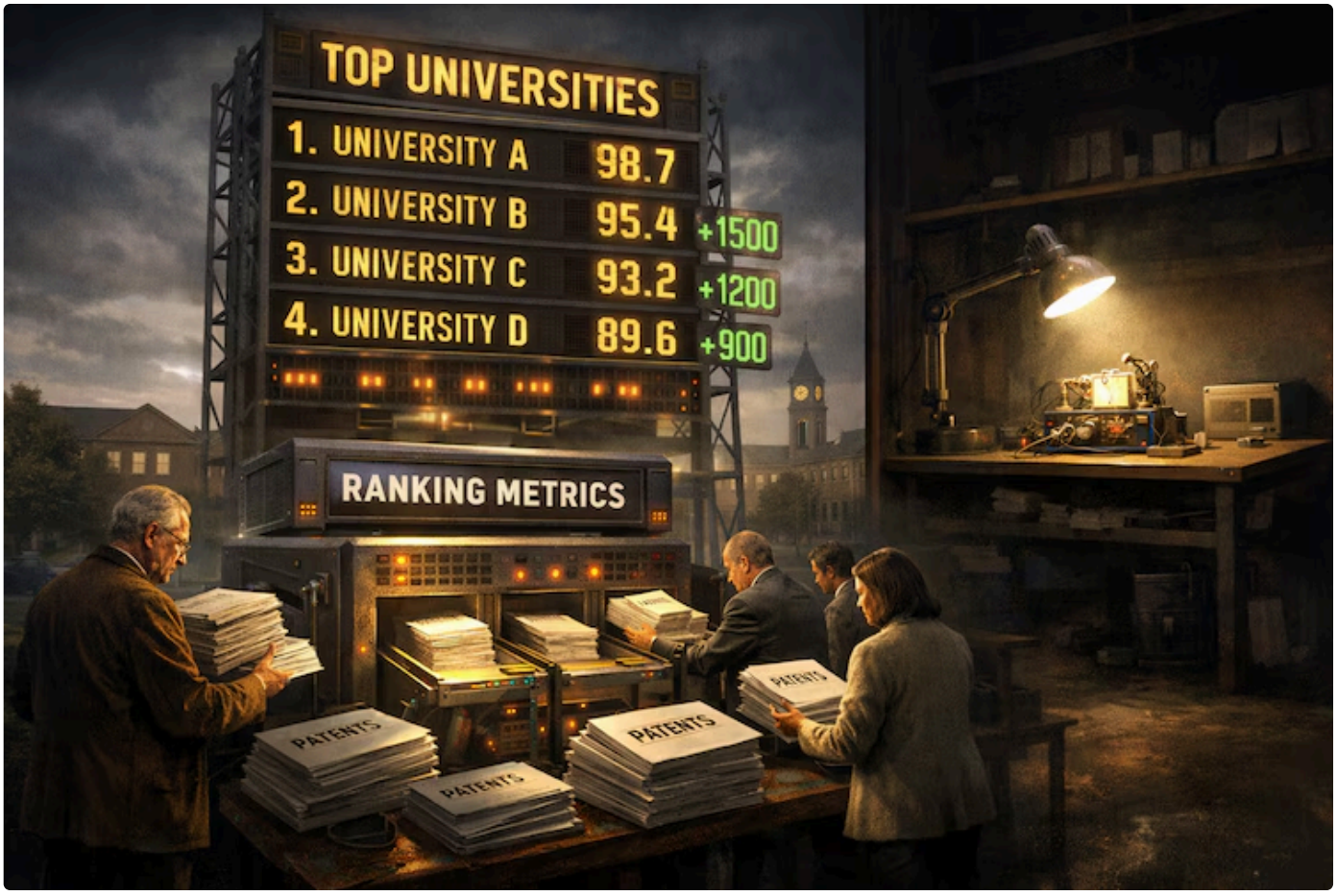
The National Institutional Ranking Framework (NIRF) and NAAC accreditation both consider research and patents.

Achal clarifies: "NIRF provides double weightage to granted patents as compared to published ones. It is important to note that almost all patents which are filed are published. There is no weightage for commercialisation in NIRF."

That last line is critical.

There is no weightage for commercialisation, so there is no major incentive other than pure innovation interests.

NAAC also asks for commercialisation details, but "the relative weightage is much lower as NAAC has a lot of parameters," he says.



(AI-generated image)

Achal's comparison of the NIRF 2024 rankings vs 2023 shows that nearly three-fourths of private universities that saw rank changes improved their positions, while a majority of public institutions with rank shifts actually slipped.

The broader trend suggests that rapid gains in research metrics, especially publications and citations, are closely tied to ranking jumps, raising concerns that quantity may be outweighing quality in the evaluation framework.

Priya is blunt: "This is the root cause of the current patenting boom. Frameworks like NIRF explicitly reward patent counts under their 'Research and Professional Practice' parameters."

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tions know that filing a high v f patents is one of the fastes to game the system and climb nkl an accreditation cycle. The m urrently reward the sheer volu filings far more than the actua of

inventions," she adds.

That is a strong allegation: gaming the system.

INTERNAL INCENTIVES: PATENTS = PROMOTIONS

Faculty incentives at private institutes matter too.

"Without a doubt, faculty evaluation provides points for patents," says Achal Agrawal. "There are direct monetary benefits for every patent published and granted. Additionally the patents are useful for promotions as well as bolstering the CV."

"There are very clear incentives. Many universities offer direct monetary rewards to faculty ranging from Rs 5,000 to Rs 15,000+ when a patent is published or granted," says Priya. "More importantly, patents carry heavy weight in Academic Performance Indicator (API) scores, which dictate faculty appraisals, promotions, and tenure."

"For us students, getting our names on a patent alongside our supervisors is a huge resume boost," she adds.

Publications in SCI/ABDC – B and above journals, reward of Rs. 50,000/- per paper.
Publication in Scopus/WoS/ABDC – C journals, reward of Rs. 20,000/- per paper.

I	Papers with two Authors	First Author	60%
		Second Author	40%
II	Papers up to three Authors	First Author	50%
		Second Author	25%
		Third Author	25%
III	Papers with more than three Authors	First Author	40%
		Remaining 60% to be divided equally in rest of the Authors	60%

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- If a faculty member publish his/her patent of research work, he/she will be rewarded with Rs. 25,000/- which is equally divided among all inventors and in case his/her patent is granted, then he/she will be rewarded with Rs. 1,00,000/- for that patent which is also equally divided among all inventors.

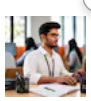
Patent incentives provided to a private university in India (provided by Achal Agrawal)

Komal confirms institutional pressure: "In many Indian universities and institutes there is noticeable pressure to file patents, particularly after the rise of NIRF/NAAC emphasis on innovation metrics."

So patents are no longer just legal tools. They have turned into performance metrics which changes the motive of filing in the first place.


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BUT HOW MANY PRIVATE UNIVERSITY PATENTS ARE GRANTED?

We have seen from data that private institutes are filing patents in massive volumes, often surpassing the collective IIT numbers. But how do the number of patents granted compare between leading public and private institutions?

An analysis of India Patent Office data (between 2020 and 2023 shows major variation in grant rates.

*[**Note:** We are using 2020–2023 data because patent grants can take up to 30 months to be processed, meaning many applications filed closer to 2025 are still under examination and not yet reflected in grant figures.]*

Top public institutes:

Institute	Patents Published	Patents Granted	Grant Rate
IITs (collectively)	3331	2,118	63.6%
IISc Bengaluru	379	257	67.8%

Notable private institutes:

Institute	Patents Published	Patents Granted	Grant Rate
LPU	5774	164	2.8%
Chandigarh University	2350	44	1.9%
Galgotias University	1752	0	0%
Shobhit Institute	563	0	0%
Jain (Deemed-to-be University)	1510	0	0%

Here is patent data for a group of major Indian educational institutes (both private and public) drawn from IPO records between 2020 and 2023:


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Institution	Patents Published	Patents Granted	Success Rate
IISc	379	257	67.8
NITs (Collectively)	933	626	67.1
IITs (Collectively)	3331	2118	63.6
BITS (Collectively)	267	77	28.8
VIT (Collectively)	279	61	21.9
Sathyabama Institute of Science & Technology	134	18	13.4
Graphic Era (Collectively)	1164	116	10.0
Presidency University	160	15	9.4
Shoolini University	549	32	5.8
SIMATS	713	36	5.0
Teerthanker Mahaveer University	1772	65	3.7
Lovely Professional University	5774	164	2.8
Chandigarh University	2350	44	1.9
Chandigarh Group of Colleges	1989	17	0.9
Jain (Deemed-to-be University)	1510	0	0.0
Galgotias University	1752	0	0.0
Shobhit Institute of Engineering & Technology	563	0	0.0

With several prominent private institutes recording 0% patent grant rates despite big patent filing and publishing numbers, we arrive at a central question:

Are universities filing patents for innovation or just for numbers?

Because patents filed are not the same as innovation created.

Achal Agrawal suggests a crucial reform: "Perhaps the government should only reimburse the fees for patents that are granted to ensure universities do not file frivolous patents. This will also ensure taxpayer money is not wasted and patent examiners get more time to verify patents in depth."

HOW MANY PATENTS TURN INTO PRODUCTS? ARE THEY JUST MARKETING NUMBERS?

After a patent is granted, it can move on to the commercialisation stage, maybe turn into an actual product with industry collaborations. But how many patents get that far?

"The conversion rate is abysmally low. Even at top-tier engineering institutes, macro data and general observation suggest that fewer than 10–15% of granted university patents ever translate into licensing deals, startups, or tangible industry collaborations," says Priya.

"Most academic patents lack a commercialisation blueprint; they are isolated lab experiments rather than solutions engineered for market integration," she adds.

Komal agrees that outside top institutes, the real-world patent innovation impact is rare.

"Institutions with stronger influence and higher ranking and industry linkages like IITs, IISC, etc still undergo licensing but for the rest, I believe the chances are rare. Most of it remains as a trophy to be shown on the CV and towards earning the University a higher/better global ranking," he says.


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(Photo: AI-generated image)

Several institutions prominently highlight patent filing numbers in promotional material to project innovation, even though prospective students and parents may not fully understand the difference between filings, grants, and real-world commercial impact.

Headlines such as LPU claiming to "lead India with 1,418 patent filings" or Galgotias University announcing its rank among "academic patent innovators" show how these numbers are often positioned as markers of prestige.

"They will proudly splash '500+ Patents Filed!' across their marketing materials to look like a massive innovation hub," says Priya.

"To prospective students or parents, it sounds incredibly impressive. But inside academia, we know that filing a patent is just a matter of paperwork and paying a fee; it completely misrepresents actual granted output or industry impact," she says.

A BROADER PATTERN: PATENTS ARE NOT THE ONLY PRESSURE AREA

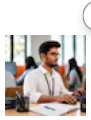
Achal Agrawal flagged another worrying research trend.

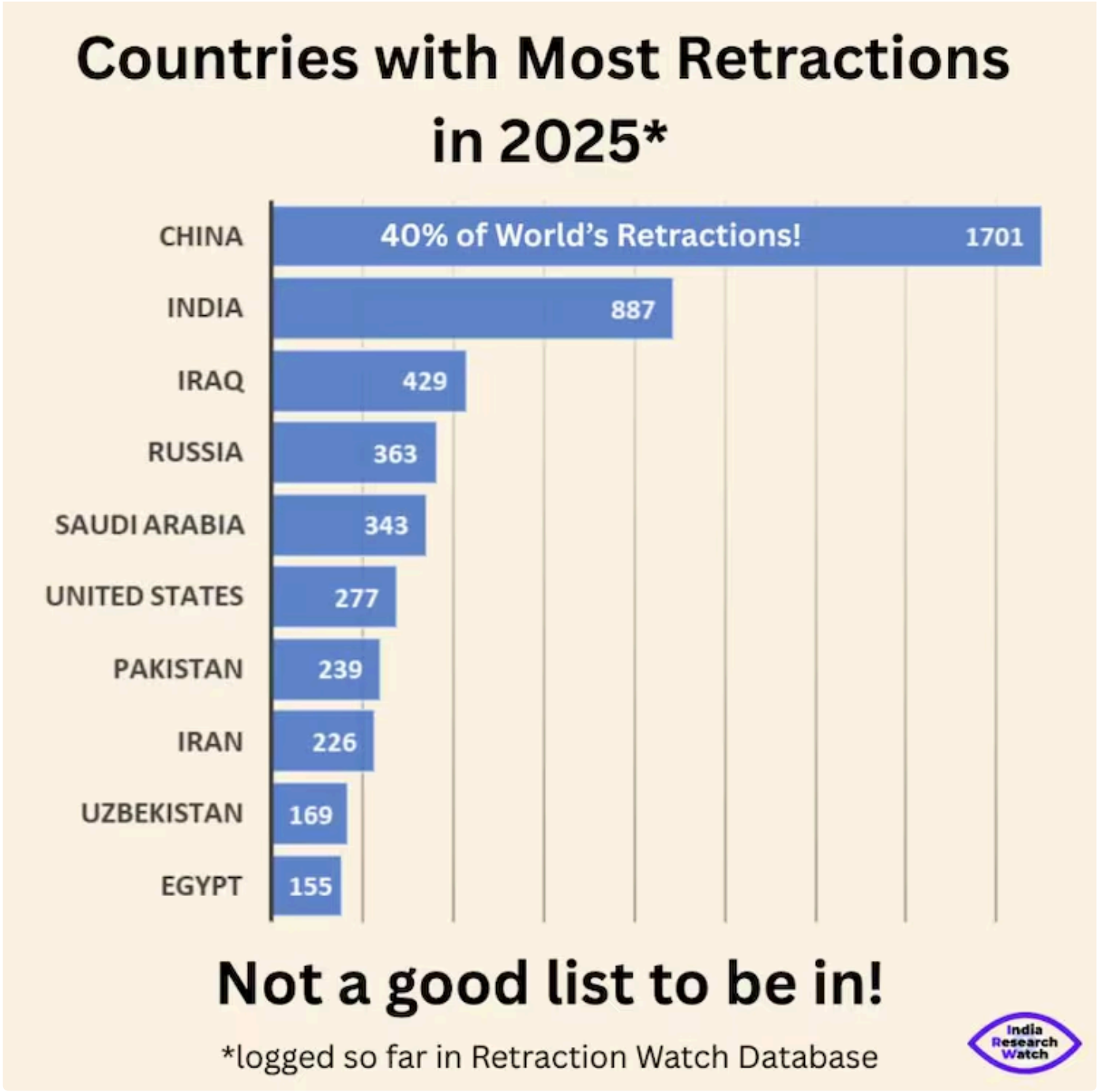
In 2025, India accounted for 21% of global research paper retractions (when published scientific studies are officially withdrawn because of serious errors, misconduct, plagiarism, or unreliable data) despite contributing around only 5% of global research output.

Six of the ten universities with the highest retractions globally in 2025 are Indian. Retractions surged post-2022, roughly aligning with post-NEP publication growth.


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Source: India Research Watch (IRW) LinkedIn post

Achal notes a strong correlation between rapid publication growth and higher retraction rates.

The parallels with patent filings is hard to ignore. When metrics reward quantity over quality, quantity increases.

SO WHAT IS THE REAL STORY WITH PATENTS?

Private universities are clearly filing patents aggressively.

Educational institute filings have grown around 62% in a single year.

India has crossed 1 lakh patent applications.

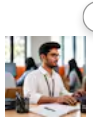
Domestic share is at an all-time high.

But:

- Filing is not granting.
- Granting is not commercialising.


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Commercialising is not societal impact.

The system currently rewards filings visibly and quickly. Grants take time. Commercialisation takes even longer.

For students and parents reading glossy brochures, "2,000 patents filed" sounds like innovation.

For policymakers, the tougher question is: how many of those become technologies that create jobs, solve real problems, and generate revenue?

Until incentives shift from volume to value, the patent boom may continue, and so will the debate.

- Ends

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About the Author

Roshni Chakrabarty

Roshni has been working in the journalism industry for over a decade, telling stories that matter. She loves writing about student innovations, latest research, and people striving to make the world better for children -- through education, social change, or environmental efforts.
With a special focus on education, the job industry, and mental health, she also enjoys uncovering lesser-known scientists and changemakers from history whose work continues to sha…
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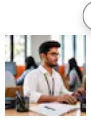
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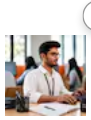
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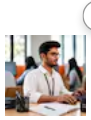

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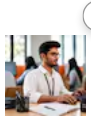

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